



EUPHEMISM

A milder or softer way of saying something harsh or awkward

1 What is it?

Euphemism (YOO-fuh-miz-um)

A euphemism is a mild, indirect or polite word or phrase used in place of one considered harsh, blunt, unpleasant or embarrassing.

a softer phrase + replaces a harsh or blunt one

2 See it in action

Death

"He **passed away** peacefully," instead of "he died."

Job loss

"She was **let go**," instead of "she was fired."

Age

"He's a bit **senior**," instead of "he's old."

Bathroom

"Where's the **restroom**?" instead of a blunter term.



Good spot!

Try spotting a euphemism your own family uses at home for an awkward topic — most families have at least one.

3 More to know

Money

"Times are **tight** this month," instead of "we're broke."

Ability

"He's a bit **unconventional**," instead of a blunter judgement.

FUN FACT

"Collateral damage" — a military euphemism for civilian casualties — is one of the most studied examples of how euphemisms can be used to make a serious reality sound clinical and distant.

4 Why it's used

Euphemism helps: soften a difficult, awkward or sensitive topic, making it easier or more polite to discuss — especially around death, illness, money or conflict.

Euphemisms appear constantly in everyday polite conversation, but writers also use them deliberately in fiction to reveal a character's personality or avoid a topic.



Quick reminder!

Ask yourself whether a euphemism is being polite, or actually hiding something important — the two uses feel very different.

5 Where you'll spot it

Softened topics

Death, money, age and job loss are the topics euphemisms cover most often in everyday speech.

A gentler substitute

Look for a milder phrase standing in for a blunter, more uncomfortable one, like 'let go' for 'fired'.

⚠ Watch out!

Euphemisms can sometimes be used to deliberately hide or downplay something serious (for example, calling job cuts "restructuring") — it's worth noticing when a euphemism is softening language versus disguising the truth.

6 Quick recap

Softens harsh language

Used for sensitive topics

Common in polite speech



Keep going!

In your own writing, a euphemism from a character's dialogue can reveal a lot about how uncomfortable they feel with a topic.